

monitored opening of *hundi*s, machine counting, presence of senior officials and vigilance staff, appraisers to evaluate precious metal donations

DIGITISE: Online transactions leave a trail, reducing scope of pilferage. Useful for non-*hundi* donations, from sevas to trust contributions

AUDIT REGULARLY: SOP at Shirdi includes a government-empanelled accounting firm rigorously checking the books, and placing annual reports before Maharashtra legislature

ENSURE ASSET TRANSPARENCY: Donations in Puri go into separate operational, foundation and corpus funds. Large sums are placed in long-term FDs; precious metals are stored in SBI lockers. The Ratna Bhandar jewellery inventory is done under CCTV surveillance in the presence of senior officials

APPOINT A CEO: Revamp current Ram Mandir Trust entirely, appoint CEO to manage affairs on a daily basis, ensure accountability and audit of donations

PASS TEMPLE ADMINISTRATION LAW: Though contentious, getting a state-supervised temple administration board, like in Kerala, TN and Andhra Pradesh, could build checks and balances

Ayodhya, meanwhile, can take a cue from the best-run temples (see *How Big Temples Guard Their Donations*). Tirupati sets the benchmark: sealed *hundi*s, secure transfer to a dedicated Parakamani centre where daily offerings are counted and segregated, CCTV-monitored opening and counting, senior officials and vigilance staff present, machine counting, appraisers for precious metals, and alternating bank deposits with SBI and Union Bank. It also demonstrates the value of digitisation: almost every non-*hundi* donation, from sevas to trust contributions, is online, reducing the scope for pilferage. Its recent controversy arose from an entirely different issue: the alleged adulteration of its famed laddoos, with cheaper vegetable oil reportedly used in place of ghee.



"There are two aspects to the investigation, 'criminal' and 'future improvement'. Only when both are addressed will we be able to regain the trust of the devotees"

—NRIPENDRA MISRA
Chairman, Ram Temple Construction Committee

A Clear Way Forward

Shirdi and Siddhivinayak exemplify a similar ethos of operational discipline. Shirdi counts cash twice a week under CCTV in the presence of bank and trust representatives and a charity commissioner; counting staff are frisked and made to wear pocketless uniforms. Siddhivinayak follows weekly CCTV-monitored counting in the presence of trustees, officials and bank representatives; gold and silver offerings are periodically auctioned, accounts audited by a government-empanelled firm and annual reports placed before the legislature. Puri's Jagannath temple swears by asset transparency. Donations are split into operational, foundation and corpus funds, with large sums placed in long-term deposits and surplus precious metals stored in SBI lockers. The Ratna Bhandar inventory, conducted under CCTV surveillance, undertakes periodic inventories of jewellery and valuables. At Somnath, there is daily reporting to trustees, next-morning bank deposits and a written SOP on when the cash box must be opened, who must be present and how cash moves within the premises.

For Ayodhya, the road ahead is clear: sealed and numbered *hundi*s, CCTV-monitored transfer and counting, mandatory presence of Trust, bank, audit and security officials, frisking and pocketless uniforms for counting staff, same- or next-day bank deposits, digital inventories of gold and silver, independent valuation, online-first donations, periodic third-party audits and annual public reports. As Nripendra Misra says, "To ensure proper management of the temple, we need a total revamp. This includes a full-time CEO to handle daily operations, enforce compliance and bring administrative accountability."

Outside, on the streets of Ayodhya, the mood remains sombre. From the tea stalls and paan kiosks to the floating, transient communities on e-rickshaws, the theft is the topic of conversation. Whether they support the BJP or the SP, whether lifelong residents or first-time visitors, everyone voices the same dismay. "I hear these things in the news, and it breaks my heart," says Ravi Kumar, a commerce postgraduate from Karnataka who copes with the loss of his family during Covid by working at a convenience store near the temple. "I do not know what to trust anymore. I came here looking for peace. Where do I find it now?" he asks in English, handing a bottle of water to a customer. A few metres away, Adarsh, a first-time pilgrim from Mysuru, holds an umbrella to shield his family from the blazing June sun. "When these things happen, it hurts our faith," he says. Faith may continue to bring the money in; but only the establishment of foolproof systems can keep it safe and permanently wipe the stain from India's most revered temple. ■

—with inputs from state bureaus